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Archival Practice in Context

This document shows the archival principles behind my work, how archival work differs from related professions, and how the context in which records were made shapes what they can tell us. Each point names the artifact in this portfolio and where it can be seen.

Part 1: Archival principles in practice

Provenance and original order guide both of my finding aids. For the Mike Williams Art Collection and the Rev. Southall Brown Collection, I decided whether the order the materials arrived in should be kept or whether a new arrangement would serve researchers better, and I recorded that decision in each finding aid. Both are described to DACS, with collection, series, and, where it helps, item-level description.

The same principles carry into preservation. In the audiocassette tape digitization, I worked from the original tapes without altering them, kept the master files separate from access copies, saved masters in an uncompressed format (WAV), and recorded who digitized each recording and when. That record ties the digital file to its original source.

I also respected the terms under which material came to the archives. The Accession Record honors a donor's 25-year restriction, and the Southall Brown finding aid names people only as the donor provided, with no further personal details (See Ethics and Permissions).

Part 2: How archival work differs from allied professions

Libraries collect published works and arrange them by subject, so one copy can usually stand in for another. Archives hold unique records and keep them together by who created them and in the order they were kept, because that context is part of the evidence. I explain this difference in my Patron Relations presentation (Slide 4).

Records management cares for an organization's records while they are still in use, through disposal or permanent keeping. Archives take over the records chosen for permanent keeping. My Records Management Policy covers that whole lifecycle and shows where the hand-off to archives happens.

Museums interpret objects for visitors. My curated displays borrow exhibit methods, but the materials remain records, described so that researchers can find and use them.

Historians and educators interpret the past; archivists preserve and describe the sources they work from. My finding aids describe without arguing a point, while my W. W. Law lesson plans

cross into teaching. That crossover reflects my background in education, but the lessons stay anchored in primary sources from the collection.

Part 3: Records in social context

Every collection here was made by someone, for a purpose, and that purpose shaped what was written down and what survived.

- The W. W. Law NAACP Collection documents Civil Rights organizing in Savannah from inside the movement's leadership.
- The Rev. Southall Brown Collection preserves a minister's papers and artifacts and the community around his work.
- The Joanna B. Flynn Civil Defense Collection reflects a period when public safety was shaped by national fears of an attack.
- The Historic Savannah East/West maps show the city as it was officially surveyed and planned by those with the authority to map it.
- The Mike Williams Art Collection records a local artist's work in his voice.
- My coursework artifacts are set in fictional corporate and institutional archives, so they show the record-keeping of organizations rather than communities.

Because these records come from leaders, institutions, and official offices, they tell only part of each story. The Selection Criteria discusses the voices this leaves out, and what I have done about them.